
Mapping Monastic Networks: The TITULI Project and the Circulation of Medieval Mortuary Rolls (8th–16th c.)

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Abstract

The **TITULI project** - *Pour une étude interdisciplinaire des rouleaux des morts* (VIII–XVI century) - is funded by the Agence Nationale de la Recherche (**ANR-24-CE27-7004**). It focuses on a category of medieval source that has remained comparatively understudied, both as a material artefact - the parchment roll as object - and as a textual record: structured lists of places and individuals that allow the simultaneous investigation of physical circulation through documented itineraries and the circulation of memory, understood as a web of relationships between religious communities.

What are mortuary rolls?

Mortuary rolls were death notices circulated by Benedictine monks and regular canons following the death of an ecclesiastical dignitary, with the dual purpose of soliciting prayers for the deceased and consolidating a community of intercession. Each roll was composed of an opening encyclical letter - the announcement of the death - followed by a series of parchment membranes on which visited institutions added their titulus: a formal response to the announcement accompanied by a commitment to prayer. In material terms, some rolls reached considerable dimensions, extending to several tens of metres in length.

The foundational edition of the corpus was produced by Jean Dufour (Dufour 2005) in five volumes, cataloguing 471 rolls dated between the eighth century and 1536. For 33 of these, Dufour further undertook a systematic toponymic identification and reconstructed the itineraries followed by the roll-bearers - routes that, in several cases, traversed regions spanning from present-day Spain and England to France and Flanders. These reconstructed

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itineraries now constitute one of the primary datasets of the TITULI project.

The project is structured around three main research axes.

Axis I - Palaeography and Diplomatics

The *tituli* offer a particularly rich corpus for the study of writing practices: hundreds of hands from different institutions, regions, and time periods are preserved on a single material support, allowing direct comparison of scribal conventions across the medieval West. This axis examines both the formal evolution of script types and the diplomatic formulae governing the composition of *tituli*, situating each institution within broader traditions of documentary practice (Venturelli 2020, Venturelli 2024).

Axis II - Materiality of the Support

Mortuary rolls are also physical objects whose material composition bears information about the networks that produced them. This axis deploys physico-chemical analyses - including X-ray fluorescence and Raman spectroscopy - to characterise the inorganic components of inks (Rabin et al 2012, Rouchon 2025, Vuillard et al 2024), and proteomic analyses to identify the animal species used in parchment production .

Axis III - Reconstructing Circulation Networks

This axis unfolds on two complementary levels, corresponding to the two modes of circulation encoded in the rolls.

At the level of physical circulation, the project uses GIS tools to superimpose reconstructed itineraries onto known road networks, particularly the Roman road network available through the Itiner-e project (<https://itiner-e.org/>) and the 18th-century Cassini cartography for France. In regions where complementary datasets are available, more granular analyses will be conducted using least-cost path algorithms and shortest-path modelling, taking into account topographic constraints (Filet and Rossi 2023, Treharne and Fafinski 2025)

At the level of memorial circulation, the dataset of 3,566 institutions and 7,430 connections makes it possible to treat the rolls as a source for network analysis: each *titulus* added by a monastery is a documented connection between two religious communities, and the totality of these connections maps the relational geography of medieval monastic Europe. Network analysis allows this map to be interrogated systematically: were the most central institutions those that were geographically best positioned, those belonging to the most powerful orders, or those embedded in networks of political alliance? Answering these questions allows us to move from a descriptive history of circulation to an explanatory history of monastic solidarities (de Valeriola 2021).

This collaborative research brings together a wide consortium: **UVSQ-DYPAC, ENS Paris-Saclay, MNHN-CRC, University of Limoges, IRHT, Rennes 2, Grenoble Alpes, the National Archives of France, and UCLouvain**. By combining digital humanities, social history, and heritage sciences.

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